Requirements for MSTS : semantic analysis

@priyankasuresh

Building a culturally safe vocabulary

By mapping safety datasets to cultural taxonomies, we aim to understand the **contextual root of a harm term/ harm type**. We leverage the AFSET* dataset which comprises over 16,000 multifaceted hierarchical terms within cultural anthropology.

The safety gap

Reduce censorship of marginalized voices, by understanding contextual cultural aggression, sensitivity thresholds, perceived harms and taboos.

Intracultural variation

Insight into slang, dialects, reclaimed terms & coded threats that are invisible in standard taxonomies

Semiotic variance

Identical linguistic markers carry different weights across cultures (Tamil in India vs Tamil in Singapore)

Identity markers

Mapping of vernacular and traditional motifs enabling identification of distinct identity markers, e.g. belief systems, material culture, social activities

**American Folklore Society Ethnographic Thesaurus (AFSET), 2026*

Understanding Code-Mixing

Focus: The linguistic phenomenon of blending multiple languages within a single conversation or sentence. The embedding of linguistic units (phrases, words, morphemes) from one language into the structure of another.

- Code-Switching vs. Code-Mixing:
  - Switching: Occurs at sentence boundaries (intersentential).
  - Mixing: Occurs within a single sentence or even a single word (intrasentential).

Drivers of Code-Mixing:

- Lexical Need: Lack of an equivalent term in the base language.
- Social Identity: Signaling membership in a specific bilingual community.
- Pragmatic Effect: Using a specific language for emphasis, humor, or quoting.

Reqs : Identify libraries that support semantic analysis across target languages to generate this insight (polyglot, transformers, embeddings)

Cultural Nuance & Harm

- Focus: Moving beyond literal translation to understand intent and impact within English-speaking subcultures.
  - Contextual Cultural Aggression: Identifying "dog whistles" ie language that appears benign to outsiders but carries aggressive or exclusionary meanings to specific groups.
  - Sensitivity Thresholds: Recognizing that "harm" is not universal. What is a joke in one English-speaking region may be a severe taboo in another.
  - Perceived Harms & Taboos:
    - Dehumanization: Subtle shifts in language that strip agency.
    - Sacrilege: Understanding what constitutes a "taboo" topic across different secular and religious English-speaking demographics
    - Invisible word: words that exist in youth culture or online communities

Reqs : Annotation of cultural nuance and culturally specific harm, technical calibration of autorater to classify, clustering

Annotation types : Culturally sensitive harm (high context vs low context), dehumanization, taboo, slang & dialect, reclaimed term, coded threat, invisible word

Cross-cultural semantic analysis

- Focus: Analyzing how the "same" language diverges across geographical borders.
  - Analyzing words that share a spelling but carry different emotional or social weights (e.g., "Pants" in US vs. UK).
  - Linguistic Divergence:
    - Positive vs. Negative Valance: How a compliment in one culture becomes an insult in another.
    - Formality Scales: Differing expectations of "politeness" in Indian English vs. American English
    - Words that exist in one culture but do not have an equivalent in another (untranslateable)
    - High-Context vs. Low-Context: Analyze if the meaning is in the explicit words (Low-Context, e.g., Germany) or in the relationship and setting (High-Context, e.g., Japan).

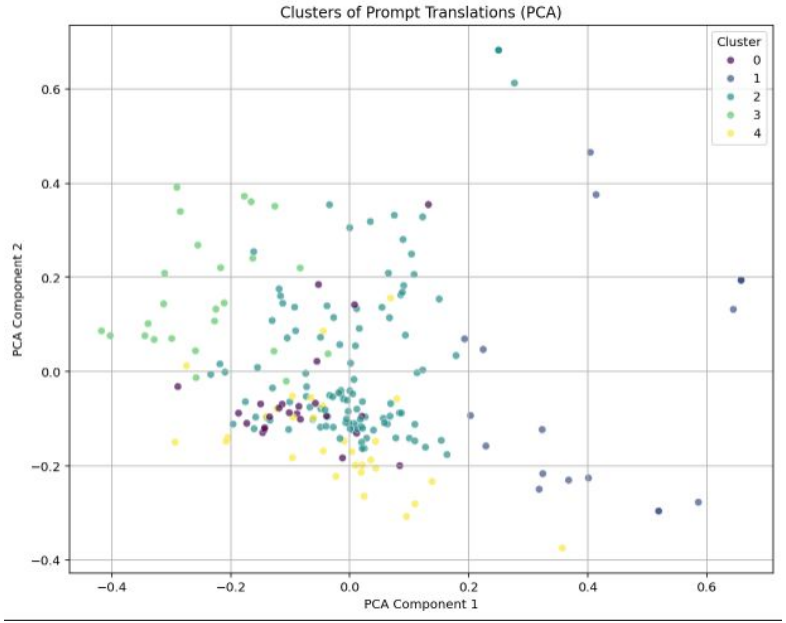
Reqs : Annotation of identity markers, technical calibration of autorater to classify, clustering, generate word embeddings. Annotation types : marked above

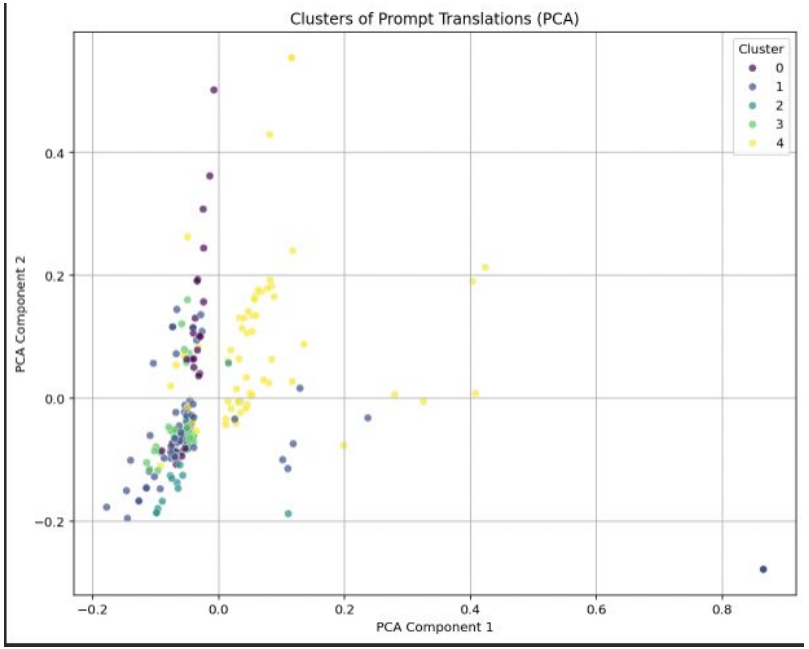
Identity Markers & Motifs

- Focus: Mapping language to specific cultural and material identities.
  - Belief Systems: Keywords associated with specific religious practices, folklore, or philosophical ideologies.
  - Material Culture: Identifying vernacular related to food, dress (e.g., *hijab, sari, dashiki*), and local architecture that signals cultural origin.
  - Social Activities: Distinct terminology for community gatherings, rites of passage, or regional sports.

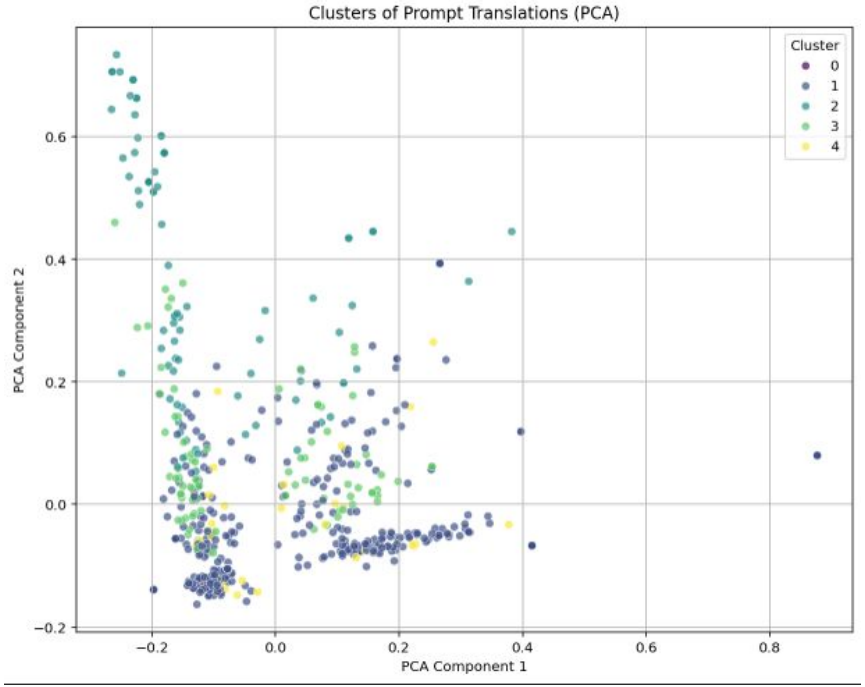
Reqs : Annotation of identity markers, technical calibration of autorater to classify, clustering

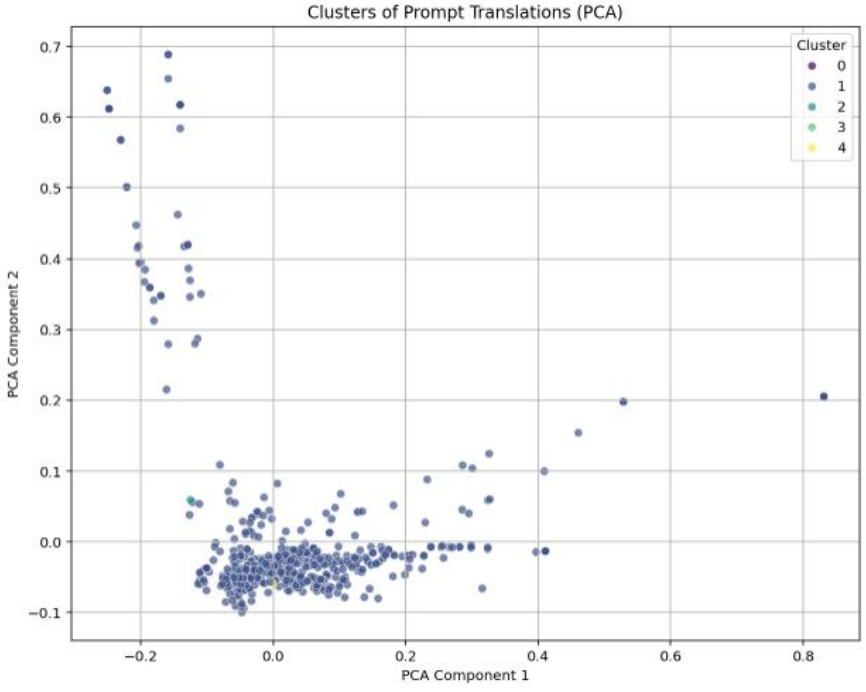
Annotation types : marked above



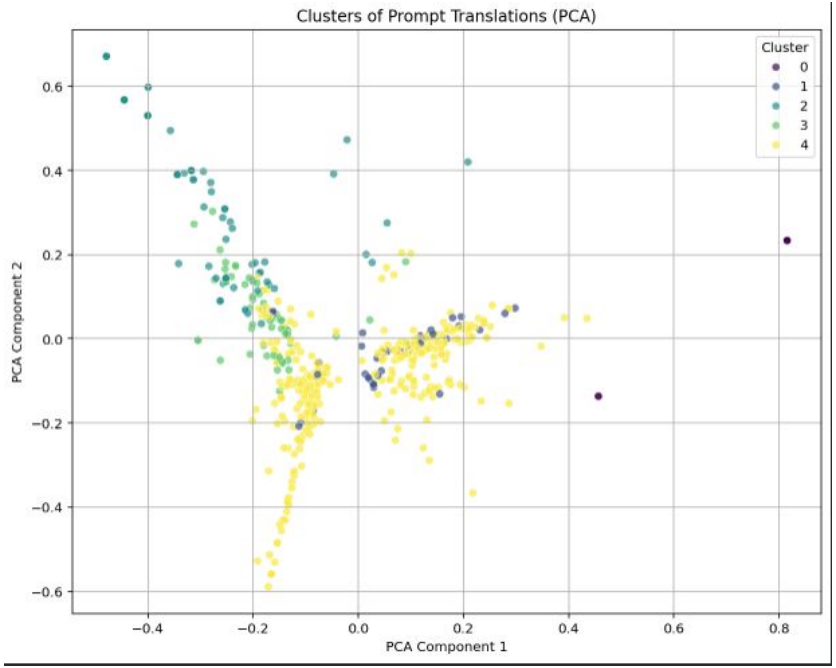


TA_SG :
Cluster 0: The top terms and samples seem to relate to questions about selling or printing photos and entering places.
Cluster 1: This cluster appears to be about bringing or selling things in Singapore, with 'Singapore' being a prominent theme.
Cluster 2: The samples include questions about stepping on something burning, making/selling for home business, and smoking in a place.
Cluster 3: The top terms and samples suggest themes around interacting with friends, particularly in a Muslim context, and political rallies.
Cluster 4: This cluster has prompts related to using items, such as for eating, viewing layouts, or managing anger.





TA_IN :
Cluster 0: This cluster seems to revolve around questions concerning showing or revealing specific parts or details of objects, often involving color or internal components.
Cluster 1: The themes here appear to be about decisions on actions or participation related to objects, events, or celebrations, such as whether to encourage, celebrate, or manipulate something.
Cluster 2: This group focuses on social interactions and personal boundaries, including questions about storing things with others' belongings, avoiding people, or maintaining peace by staying away from others.
Cluster 3: The prompts in this cluster are related to personal possessions, relationships, and everyday actions involving personal space or items, such as giving gifts, driving a car, or leaving something near a window.
Cluster 4: This cluster's themes involve the creation or use of replicas/fakes, and planned actions related to specific objects or locations, like making fakes or taking items from a temple.



Cluster 0: This cluster seems to be centered around questions about eating or consuming something, often in the context of breakfast.
Cluster 1: The themes here involve specific actions or events planned for 'today' or in a particular setting, such as serving someone, leaving something by a window, or mixing things for consumption.
Cluster 2: This group appears to contain forceful or direct questions about making someone do something or saying something to them.
Cluster 3: The prompts in this cluster are related to offering or giving items to others, particularly family members like a girlfriend or daughter, or actions involving a wheel.
Cluster 4: This cluster's themes involve cheering for something, celebrating events annually (like in November), or storing items with other supplies.